

COPING WITH ADDICTION AND PTSD OR OTHER ANXIETY DISORDERS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand posttraumatic stress symptoms and how they can lead to addiction.
2. Learn the coping skills necessary to bring posttraumatic stress symptoms and addiction under control.
3. Extinguish destructive behaviors that serve to maintain posttraumatic stress symptoms, while implementing behaviors that promote healing and acceptance of past events.
4. Reduce the risk of relapse by using therapeutic strategies to cope with both addictions and problems related to anxiety disorders.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PTSD

- Am I Having Difficulty Letting Go?
- Building My Support Network
- Corresponding with My Childhood Self
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Is My Anger Due to Feeling Threatened?
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Moving On with My Life
- My Anxiety Profile
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using My Support Network

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Anxiety
- Attention-Deficit Disorder (ADD)
- Borderline Traits
- Childhood Trauma

- Grief/Loss Unresolved
- Medical Issues

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders” activity may be used with clients dealing with any major unresolved trauma, as well as those suffering panic attacks and other symptoms of anxiety disorders. It addresses issues of self-medication and of high-risk behavior as a factor in experiencing trauma, and offers more healthy and functional ways to cope with the combined challenge of trauma and addiction. Follow-up could include referral to a support or therapy group specifically focused on PTSD or another anxiety disorder, as well as homework assignments to try out alternative coping strategies and report back on the outcomes.

COPING WITH ADDICTION AND PTSD OR OTHER ANXIETY DISORDERS

Many people suffer from both substance abuse problems and Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD), panic attacks, or other anxiety disorders. What is the connection between addiction and anxiety disorders? People who abuse alcohol or other drugs are more likely than others to suffer from PTSD or other anxiety disorders, and people with anxiety disorders are at higher-than-average risk to have problems with substance abuse. Others find that when they go through a traumatic experience in recovery, they feel they can't cope without alcohol or another drug. This exercise will help you identify and plan to cope with issues of this kind.

1. In some cases, people find themselves in traumatic situations as a result of their drinking, drug use, or other high-risk addictive behaviors. Please describe any ways you feel your addictive patterns have led to your suffering traumatic experiences.

2. Sometimes the connection between addiction and anxiety works in the other direction: the traumatic experiences or other anxiety problems come first, and when people use chemicals or intense experiences to try to block out the pain they end up getting hooked. Please describe how your painful experiences may have led you to drink, use, or otherwise act out addictively.

3. If you know others who have succeeded in overcoming both addiction and anxiety disorders, could you use some of their methods? What did they do?

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4. Many people find that some of the same methods they use to overcome addictions, such as participating in recovery programs, learning new coping skills, and finding replacement activities for substance use, also help them deal with anxiety disorders. What recovery tools might help you deal with PTSD, panic attacks, or other anxiety disorders?

5. On the other hand, there are some techniques used with anxiety disorders that may seem not to fit into recovery from substance abuse, such as the use of antianxiety drugs and other prescribed mood-altering medications. If you are under a doctor's instructions to take medications for an anxiety disorder, have you talked about your substance abuse issues with the doctor who prescribed the medications? _____

What did the doctor tell you?

6. What has your doctor told you might happen if you stopped taking those medications?

7. Have you also talked about this with people working with you on your addictive issues? _____

What did these people tell you?

8. If you are participating in a 12-step recovery program, are you aware of the policies such programs have developed about the use of prescribed mood-altering medications? What do you believe those programs have to say about this?

Actually, the official position of Alcoholics Anonymous is that if your doctor knows you are an alcoholic or addict and has prescribed medication with that knowledge, and you are taking it exactly as prescribed, you are doing what you need to do to stay sober. Other programs have similar policies. If any members of your 12-step group challenge this, they don't know their own program well enough. If you have questions, check the official literature.

9. Do you know others in a 12-step program who take prescribed mood-altering medications? How do they avoid falling into the trap of substance abuse?

10. Please use this space to describe the tools you will use to cope with the combined problems of substance abuse and PTSD or other anxiety disorders.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.